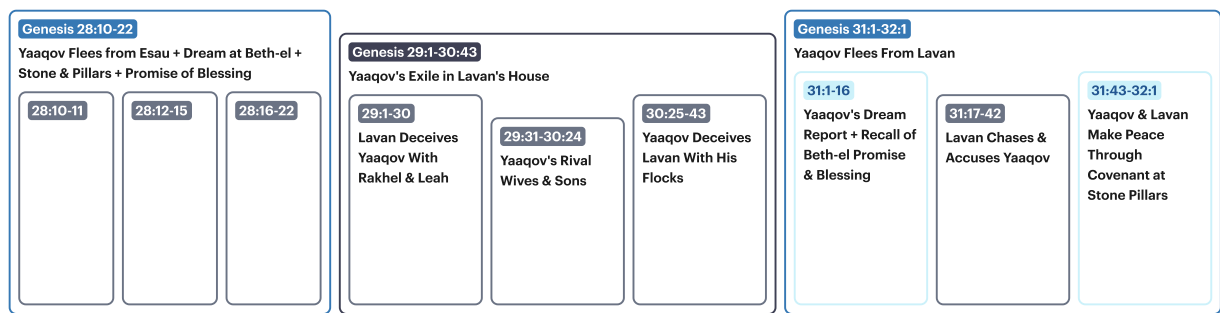


Session 12: Jacob at the Gate of Heaven

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov’s response subtly twists God’s promise of blessing and presence into a bargaining arrangement.
- Yaaqov seeing the gate of Heaven in a dream points to an awareness of heavenly realities not accessible to our conscious senses.
- Jesus envisions himself as the ramp that provides a way for Heaven and Earth to be united as one.

Yaaqov's Exile in the House of Lavan



Genesis 28:10-32:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The chart above is adapted from Andrew Teeter's "Genesis Class Notes" and from the principles in his essay, ["Biblical Symmetry and Its Modern Detractors,"](#) a paper delivered at the 2019 International Organization for the Study of the Old Testament.

This section makes up the center of the Yaaqov narrative, and it recounts his 20-year exile in Kharan, the place from which his grandfather Abraham migrated to Canaan. Here, Yaaqov's deception is turned back upon him by his uncle Lavan, and what he did to his father and brother is now done to him. The deceptions and counter-deceptions escalate, and the only thing that brings this deception-fest to a halt is a covenant of peace between brothers.

The three parts of this section have an overall symmetrical design.

Genesis 28:10-22

God Appears to Yaaqov at Beth-el

- 28:12 God appears “in a dream” during the night
- 28:13 God appears as the “Elohim of Avraham and Yitskhaq, your fathers”
- “Look, I am with you”
- “I will return you to this land”
- 28:18 Yaaqov took a stone (אבן) and set up a standing-pillar (מצבה)

- **28:20** Yaaqov vows a vow (נדר) to be loyal to Yahweh

Genesis 29:1-30:43

Yaaqov's Exile in Lavan's house

Genesis 31:1-32:1

- **31:1-16 God Appears to Yaaqov in Exile**
 - **31:10** God appears "in a dream"
 - "Return to the land of your fathers and your birth-family"
 - "and I will be with you"
 - "return to the land of your birth-family"
- **31:17-42 Lavan Chases after Yaaqov**
- **31:43-32:1 Yaaqov and Lavan Make a Covenant of Peace**
 - **31:45** Yaaqov took a stone (אבן) and set up a standing-pillar
 - **31:53** Yaaqov swears an oath (שבע) to keep his promise to Lavan
 - **31:53** Yaaqov swears by "the Elohim of Nahor, Avraham, and Yitskhaq"

Genesis 28:10-32:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov Meets God at Bethel

¹⁰ And Yaaqov went out from Beer-Sheva (שבע • = "seven/oath")

and he went to Haran

¹¹ And he encountered the place,

and he stayed the night there, for the sun had gone down

and he took from the stones (אבן) of the place,

and he set his head-rest (מראשתיו)

and he laid down in that place.

¹² And he had a dream

and behold, a ramp was set (מצב) on the land,

and its head (ראש) was in the skies

and behold, messengers of Elohim were going up and going down upon it.

¹³ And behold, Yahweh stood (נצב) upon it and said,

"I myself (אני) am Yahweh the Elohim of Abraham your father and the Elohim of Yitskhaq your father;

the land that you are lying on,

to you I will give it, and to your seed.

¹⁴ And your seed will be like the dust of the land,

and you will break out to the west, and to the east, and to the north, and to the south,

and in you all the families of **the ground** will find blessing, and in your seed.

15 **And behold**, I myself (אנכי) am with you
and I will keep you everywhere you go
and I will return you back to **this ground**,
indeed, I will not abandon you
until I do what I have spoken to you.”

16 And Yaaqov woke up from his sleep,
and he said,

“Surely **Yahweh** is in **this place** ,
and I did not know it.”

17 And Yaaqov was afraid,
and he said,

“How fearful is **this place** ,
this is none other than the **house of Elohim [= “Beth-Elohim”]** ,
and this is **the gate** (שער) of **the skies** .”

18 And Yaaqov got up **in the morning**
and he took **the stone** (אבן) which he set for **a head-rest** (מראשתיו) ,
and he set it as **a pillar** (מצבה) ,
and he poured olive oil upon **its head** (ראשה) ,
19 and he called the name of **that place** , **“Beth-El” [= “House of El”]**
Now, Luz (“Almond-tree”) was the name of the city **at its beginning** (ראשנה) .

20 And Yaaqov **vowed a vow** (וידר...נדר) , saying:

“If **Elohim** will be with me,
and keep me on this path which I am going
and if he will give me bread to eat and clothing to wear,

21 and if I return to the house of my father,
then **Yahweh** will be my **Elohim**,

22 and then **the stone** (אבן) which I placed as **a pillar** (מצבה) ,
it will be a **house of Elohim [= “Beth-Elohim”]**
and then everything which you will give me,
I will surely **tithe a tenth** (עשר אעשרנו) of it to you.”

Genesis 28:10-22. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Leaving Canaan, Leaving Eden

As Yaaqov leaves the land promised to Abraham’s seed, he encounters divine messengers coming and going between the skies and the land. He happens upon a portal, as it were, between Heaven and Earth. This is a not-very-subtle recall of the cherubim that Yahweh posted at the entrance of Eden when he exiled the humans.

Genesis 3:22-24 Instructor's Translation

²² And Yahweh Elohim said,

“Look, the human has become like one of us, knowing good and bad,
and now so that he won’t send out his hand and take also from the tree of life,
and eat and live forever ...”

²³ and Yahweh Elohim sent him out from the garden
to work the ground from which he was taken.

²⁴ **And he banished the human**

and he made to dwell at the east of the garden of Eden

cherubim and the flame of the whirling sword to guard the way to the tree of life.

The strength of this analogy is bolstered by the fact that when Yaaqov returns from his exile in Lavan’s house and crosses back into the land, he has another encounter with divine messengers.

Genesis 28:10-22

- Yaaqov meets “divine messengers” (מלאכי אלהים) at the border of the land
- “And he said, ‘This is the house of El!’”
- “And he called the name of the place, ‘House of El.’”

Genesis 29-31

- Yaaqov’s exile in Lavan’s house

Genesis 32:2-3

- Yaaqov meets “divine messengers” (מלאכי אלהים) at the border of the land
- “And he said, ‘This is the camp of Elohim’”
- “And he called the name of the place ‘Two-Camps’”

Genesis 28:10-32:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

There is another important parallel between the exile of Adam and Eve and Yaaqov. In the midst of a tragic departure, God promises that a future seed will restore the Eden blessing to the world.

God’s Curse on the Snake

Gen. 3:14-15 And Yahweh Elohim said to the snake,
“Because you have done this thing,
you are cursed more than every beast
and more than every living creature of the field;

God’s Blessing on the Snake-like Yaaqov

Gen. 28:13-14 ... “I am Yahweh,
the Elohim of Avraham your father,
and the Elohim of Yitskhaq your father;
the land that you are lying on,
to you I will give it, and to **your seed,**

Blessing the Snake-like Yaaqov. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

God's Curse on the Snake

on your belly you will go,
and dust you will eat,
all the days of your life.
And I will set hostility
between you and the woman,
and between your seed and **her seed**;
he will strike your head
and you will strike his heel."

God's Blessing on the Snake-like Yaaqov

and **your seed** will be like the dust of the land,
and you will break out to the west and to the east
and to the north and to the south,
and in you all the families of the land will find
blessing, and in **your seed**."

Blessing the Snake-like Yaaqov. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

However, notice the contrast. Yaaqov is likened to the deceitful snake (both are heel-strikers), but instead of receiving a curse, God gives him a blessing. Instead of a sentence of death, he is given a promise of life.

Heaven and Earth, Angels and Ultimate Reality

The imagery of Yaaqov's dream reveals a core aspect of the Bible's portrait of reality: Heaven and Earth are distinct realms, but they're not wholly separate. Rather, they are made for one another, and they intersect and overlap in ways that humans only dimly perceive. Eden is the foundational biblical image of a realm where Heaven and Earth are one. But this story takes us one step further, and it shows us how Heaven and Earth can overlap when a person's consciousness is heightened to awareness of this overlap.

The fact that Yaaqov is asleep and dreaming, and this is what makes him able to perceive Heaven's presence linked to Earth, is of greatest significance. Our normal, socialized, conscious states only make us aware of some aspects of reality.

The dream is also an Eden image, where the first "dream" is alluded to when *Elohim* causes a deep sleep to fall upon the human so that he can be divided into two (see [Gen. 2:18-25](#)).

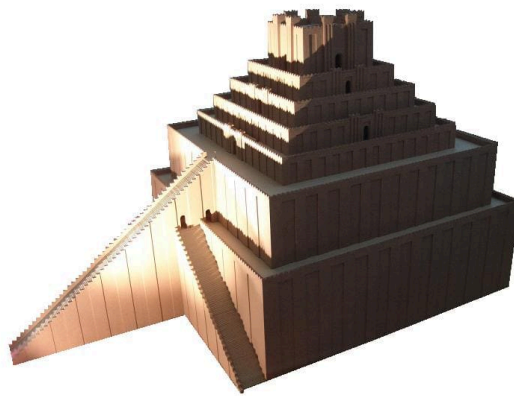
Genesis 28:12 Instructor's Translation

And he had a dream
and behold,
a ramp was set **on the land**,
and **its head** was **in the skies**
and behold,
messengers of *Elohim* were going up and going down upon it.

The Hebrew word for "ramp," or possibly "stairway," is *sullam* (סֻלָּם), and it appears only here in all of ancient Hebrew literature. It is related to the word *similtu* in Akkadian, a ancient cognate Semitic language related to Hebrew, which means "stepped ramp" and could refer to the tall, ascending stairways that lead to the top of Mesopotamian ziggurats, sacred temples that connected Heaven and Earth with an altar on top.

The great Etemenanki ziggurat in Babylon, and the accompanying Esagila temple, was one of the largest temple structures in the ancient world. It was built, remodeled, and rebuilt several times within the 700 years

between the 14th and 7th century B.C.E.



Mustafin, O. (2006) [Wikipedia Commons](#)

“Etemenanki” is Sumerian for “Tower of the Foundation of Heaven and Earth.” Its origins in the 14th century are mentioned in the famous Babylonian epic of creation *Enuma Elish*, which tells of Marduk’s rise to power as the old Babylonian empire came to dominate Mesopotamia in the 1200s B.C.E.

The point of this image is that Yaaqov is seeing the reality to which ancient temples pointed: the intersection of Heaven and Earth, of the divine and human realms in one place.

Eden, Babylon, and Bethel

Yaaqov's exile is also set on analogy to the sons of Noah who go east and attempt to build their own cosmic mountain that reaches to the skies.

Genesis 11

¹ Now the whole land was one language and one in words.

² And it came about as **they journeyed east** that they found a plain in the land of Shinar and they settled there.

³ And they said each to his neighbor, “Come, let us brick bricks and burn them as burnt.”
And they used brick for stone, and they used tar for mortar.

⁴ And they said,
“Come, **let us build for ourselves a city**,
and **a tower whose head will be in the skies**,

Genesis 27-29

Gen. 29:1 And Yaaqov lifted his feet, and **he went to the land of the sons of the East**.

Gen. 28:17 This is none other than the house of Elohim, and **this is the gate of the skies.**

Gen. 27:18-19 ¹⁸ And Yaaqov got up in the morning,
and he took the stone which he placed for a head-space, **and he placed it as a standing-stone**, and poured olive oil upon its head, ¹⁹ and he called the name of that place Beth-El (= “House of Elohim”).

Journey East and a Tower to the Skies. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Genesis 11

and let us make for ourselves a name,
lest we be scattered upon the face of all the
land.”

...

⁹ Therefore its name was called **Babylon**, because
there Yahweh made-babble of the language of all
the land, and from there Yahweh scattered them
upon the face of all the land.

Genesis 27-29

Gen. 27:22 And then **this stone which I placed as
a standing-stone, it will be a House of Elohim** (lit.
“Beth-El”)

Journey East and a Tower to the Skies. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

There is an important contrast here between Yaaqov's experience and the Babylonian builders.

- The Babylonians are actively attempting to build their way back up to the heavens. Yaaqov is a passive recipient of the vision. His inactivity emphasizes that the connection between Heaven and Earth cannot be achieved by humans, but only received as a gift.
- The Hebrew word for Babylon is *bavel*, (בבל) which is a Hebrew spelling of the Akkadian word *bab-il*, which means “gate of the gods.” Notice that this is precisely what Yaaqov calls the stair-ramp he sees in his vision.

Within the compositional design of Genesis 1-11, the story of the building of Babylon forms a crucially important match to the story of Eden. The fact that both stories are being hyperlinked to within this story about Yaaqov shows the author's awareness of their linkage.

Genesis 1:1-2:3

- Creation out of the waters

Genesis 2:4-3:24

- Eden = cosmic mountain where heaven and earth are one
- Blessing, failure, and curse in the garden
- Exile to the east of the garden

Genesis 4-5

- Cain's violence and further exile from Eden
- **He builds a city for his own family name, and its outcry reaches up to God**

Genesis 6:1-9:17

- De-creation and re-creation by the waters

Genesis 9:18-27

- Ararat = cosmic mountain where Heaven and Earth are reconciled
- Blessing, failure, and curse in the vineyard garden
- Exile to the east of Eden

Genesis 9:28-11:9

- Ham's descendants are further exiled from Eden
- **The building of the city of Babylon for their own name, and its arrogance reaches up to God**

Genesis 25:19-34

- Creation of Yitskhaq's sons out

Genesis 26:28-9

- Canaan = A new Eden where

Genesis 28:10-22

- Yaaqov is further exiled from

Eden, Babylon, and Bethel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

of an infertile womb	God’s blessing is realized in a time of famine • Blessing, failure, and non-blessing in the new Eden • Yaaqov exiled to the east	the new Eden • He encounters Heaven and Earth, and he builds a sacred pillar named “House of El” that will eventually become an Israelite temple
Eden, Babylon, and Bethel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

The Blessing of Abraham, Yitskhaq, and Yaaqov

God’s words to Yaaqov blend together phrases from God’s blessing speeches to both Abraham and Yitskhaq.

God’s Promise to Yaaqov: Genesis 28:13-15	God’s Promises to Yitskhaq and Abraham
I am the Lord, the God of your father Abraham and the God of Yitskhaq;	Gen. 26:24 (God to Yitskhaq) I am the God of Abraham your father
the land on which you lie, I will give it to you and to your seed . Your seed will also be like the dust of the earth , and you will spread out to the west and to the east and to the north and to the south ;	Gen. 13:14-17 (God to Abraham) ¹⁴ Now lift up your eyes and look from the place where you are, northward and southward and eastward and westward ; ¹⁵ for all the land which you see, I will give it to you and to your seed forever. ¹⁶ I will make your seed as the dust of the earth , so that if anyone can number the dust of the earth, then your seed can also be numbered. ¹⁷ Arise, walk about the land through its length and breadth; for I will give it to you .
God’s Promises to Yaaqov, Abraham, and Yitskhaq. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

God's Promise to Yaaqov: Genesis 28:13-15	God's Promises to Yitskhaq and Abraham
and all the families of the ground (משפחות האדמה) will discover blessing (ונברכו) through you (בך) and through your seed (בזרעך) .	Gen. 12:3 And all the families of the ground (משפחות האדמה) will discover blessing (ונברכו) through you (בך) Gen. 22:18 And all the nations (גוי) of the land will discover blessing (והתברכו) through your seed (בזרעך) Gen. 26:4 And all the nations (גוי) of the land will discover blessing (והתברכו) through your seed (בזרעך)
Behold, I am with you (אנכי עמך)	Gen. 26:3 I will be with you (עמך)
<i>God's Promises to Yaaqov, Abraham, and Yitskhaq. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

Yaaqov's Two Curious Responses

Yaaqov takes God's promises and turns them into negotiating points.

Yahweh's Promise	Yaaqov's Negotiated Response
Gen. 28:13b-15 And he said, "I am Yahweh the God of Avraham your father and the God of Yitskhaq your father; the land that you are lying on, to you I will give it, and to your seed, and your seed will be like the dust of the land, and you will break out to the west, and to the east, and to the north, and to the south and in you all the families of the land will find blessing, and in your seed. And behold, I am with you, and I will keep you everywhere you go and I will return you back to this land,	Gen. 28:20-22 And Yaaqov vowed a vow, saying: " If God will be with me, and if he will keep me on this path which I am going, and if he will give me bread to eat and clothing to wear, and if I return to the house of my father, then Yahweh will be my God . And then this stone which I placed as a pillar, it will be a house of God, and then everything which you will give me, I will surely offer a tenth of it to you."
<i>Yaaqov's Two Curious Responses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

Yahweh's Promise

Yaaqov's Negotiated Response

and I will not abandon you
until I do what I have spoken to you."

Yaaqov's Two Curious Responses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov takes God's promise of protection and blessing and turns it into a transactional obligation on God's part.

Yahweh offers to give the blessing of Yaaqov's ancestors to him as a gift, but Yaaqov turns it into a condition: Yahweh can be his God if he protects him.

Notice that Yaaqov reduces the cosmic scope of the divine promises down to the confines of his own personal survival ("food and clothing") and return to the land. God's promise to Yaaqov is about his seed, the land, fruitfulness, and blessing for the nations. Yaaqov's response only repeats what is important for his personal survival (note that "food and clothing" is exactly what Yaaqov used to deceive his brother and father).

"Jacob the trickster is now bound to this God who presides over all the trickery yet to come in the narrative. God has been committed to Jacob since the oracle of [25:23](#). But only now is Jacob also bound. Jacob's response strikes one as a genuine act of faith. But Jacob will be Jacob. Even in this solemn moment, he still sounds like a bargain-hunter. He still adds an 'if' ([v. 20](#))."

Brueggemann, Walter (1982). [Genesis: Interpretation, A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 248.

After negotiating with God's promise, Yaaqov goes on to promise to build God a temple—something that God has not asked for. This is similar to David's offer to build a temple for God when God never asked for such a thing.

2 Samuel 7:1-7 NASB

¹ Now it came about when the king lived in his house, and the LORD had given him rest on every side from all his enemies, ² that the king said to Nathan the prophet, "See now, I dwell in a house of cedar, but the ark of God dwells within tent curtains." ³ Nathan said to the king, "Go, do all that is in your mind, for the LORD is with you."

⁴ But in the same night, the word of the LORD came to Nathan, saying, ⁵ "Go and say to my servant David, 'Thus says the LORD, "**Are you the one who should build me a house to dwell in?**" ⁶ For I have not dwelt in a house since the day I brought up the sons of Israel from Egypt, even to this day; but I have been moving about in a tent, even in a tabernacle. ⁷ Wherever I have gone with all the sons of Israel, **did I speak a word with one of the tribes of Israel,** which I commanded to shepherd my people Israel, saying, '**Why have you not built me a house of cedar?**'"'"

[Genesis 28:10-22](#) is the founding story of the temple at Bethel, which will later become an idolatrous center of worship for the estranged tribes of Israel and eventually lead to Israel's destruction and exile.

1 Kings 12:28-32 NASB

²⁸ So the king consulted, and made **two golden calves**, and he said to them, “It is too much for you to go up to Jerusalem; behold your gods, O Israel, that brought you up from the land of Egypt.”

²⁹ **He set one in Bethel**, and the other he put in Dan.

³⁰ Now **this thing became a sin**, for the people went to worship before the one as far as Dan.

³¹ And he made houses on high places, and made priests from among all the people who were not of the sons of Levi. ³² Jeroboam instituted a feast in the eighth month on the fifteenth day of the month, like the feast which is in Judah, and he went up to the altar; **thus he did in Bethel, sacrificing to the calves which he had made.** And **he stationed in Bethel the priests of the high places which he had made.**

Amos 3:14 NASB

For on the day that I punish Israel’s transgressions, **I will also punish the altars of Bethel;** the horns of the altar will be cut off and they will fall to the ground.

Amos 4:4-5 NIV

⁴ “**Go to Bethel and sin;** go to Gilgal and sin yet more. Bring your sacrifices every morning, your tithes every three years. ⁵ Burn leavened bread as a thank offering and brag about your freewill offerings—boast about them, you Israelites, for this is what you love to do,” declares the Sovereign LORD.

Amos 5:5-6 NASB

⁵ But do not resort to Bethel and do not come to Gilgal, nor cross over to Beersheba; for Gilgal will certainly go into captivity **and Bethel will come to trouble.**

⁶ Seek the LORD that you may live,
or he will break forth like a fire,
O house of Joseph,
and **it will consume with none to quench it for Bethel,**

Bethel, the Son of Man, and Jesus

This story is alluded to in an important moment in the Gospel of John, where Jesus is assembling a symbolic restored Israel.

John 1:44-51 NASB

⁴⁴ Now Philip was from Bethsaida, of the city of Andrew and Peter. ⁴⁵ Philip found Nathanael and said to him, “We have found him of whom Moses in the Law and also the Prophets wrote—Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph.” ⁴⁶ Nathanael said to him, “Can any good thing come out of Nazareth?” Philip said to him, “Come and see.”

⁴⁷ Jesus saw Nathanael coming to him, and said of him, “Behold, **an Israelite indeed, in whom there is no deceit!**”

⁴⁸ Nathanael said to him, “How do you know me?” Jesus answered and said to him, “Before Philip called you, **when you were under the fig tree, I saw you.**”

⁴⁹ Nathanael answered him, “Rabbi, you are the Son of God; you are the King of Israel.”

⁵⁰ Jesus answered and said to him, “Because I said to you that I saw you under the fig tree, do you believe? You will see greater things than these.”

⁵¹ And he said to him, “Truly, truly, I say to you, **you will see the heavens opened and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man.**”

John here retells the story of Nathanael’s calling into the group of Jesus’ disciples. However, he has told the story in order to portray Jesus as Yahweh, summoning a morally transformed (= new covenant) Yaaqov/Israel to follow him.

Nathanael is presented as a renewed Israel, being summoned as a new Adam (from “under the tree”) to follow Jesus into a new Eden (= a renewed and united Heaven and Earth).

The hyperlinks that John is activating show how the Yaaqov story was understood in relationship to the larger themes about Yaaqov at work in the TaNaK.

Jesus and Nathanael	Yaaqov and the Prophets
John 1:47 Jesus saw Nathanael coming to him, and said of him, “Behold, an Israelite indeed, in whom there is no deceit !”	Gen. 27:35 But Yitskhaq said to Esau, “Your brother Jacob (Heb. yaaqov = “deceiver”) came with deceit (Heb. mirmah) and he has taken away your blessing.” Zeph. 3:12-13, 15 But I will leave among you a humble and lowly people, and they will take refuge in the name of the Lord. The remnant of Israel will do no wrong and tell no lies , nor will a tongue of deceit (Heb. tarmit) be found in their mouths; for they will feed and lie down with no one to make them afraid . The King of Israel, the Lord, is in your midst ; you will fear disaster no more.
John 1:48-49 Nathanael said to him, “How do you know me?” Jesus answered and said to him, “Before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree , I saw you.” Nathanael answered him, “Rabbi, you are the Son of God; you are the King of Israel .”	Mic. 4:4 But they will sit, each man under his own vine and under his own fig tree , and no one will make them afraid Zech. 3:8-10 “For behold, I am going to bring my servant, Branch ... and I will remove the iniquity of that land in one day. In that day,” declares the Lord of hosts, “every one of you will invite his neighbor

Hyperlinks to the Jacob Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Jesus and Nathanael	Yaaqov and the Prophets
	to under his vine and under his fig tree .” 1 Kgs. 4:21, 25 Now Solomon ruled over all the kingdoms ... So Judah and Israel lived in safety, every man under his vine and his fig tree
<i>Hyperlinks to the Jacob Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

Reflection Question

How is Yaaqov’s vow to build God a house a parody of the vision God gave him?